Job Preferences and Wage Expectations Among Ghanaian University Graduates

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Abstract

This report summarises preliminary findings from a baseline survey of 48 Ghanaian university graduates on their wage expectations and the factors that influence their job-choice decisions. Regression analysis reveals that professional development is positively associated with both the minimum and maximum acceptable wage, while two stated social influences, family and peer opinion, are associated only with the maximum: family opinion is associated with a lower ceiling wage and peer opinion with a higher one. These are exploratory patterns intended to inform the design of a pilot RCT.

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1 Background and Data

The survey was administered to Ghanaian university graduates through KoboCollect. Respondents provided their minimum and maximum willingness-to-accept (WTA) wages (the floor and ceiling of pay they would consider for a job offer), along with demographic information and a set of indicators for which factors (e.g. location, hours flexibility, professional development) influence their employment decisions.

Because respondents entered wages in free text, responses arrived in diverse formats: monthly figures (“GHC 2,000”), hourly rates (“15 Ghana Cedis per hour”), daily rates, ranges (“1,500–2,000”), and even written-out words (“two thousand”). All entries were algorithmically standardised to a **monthly GHC equivalent** using a 40-hour, five-day working week (approximately 173 hours per month and 21.7 working days per month). Range entries were represented by their midpoint.

The analytical sample was constructed from the raw survey responses in two steps. First, respondents who were not college graduates were dropped (grad_code = 3; $n = 1$ dropped). Second, respondents missing wage data for both the minimum and maximum WTA, or missing any key demographic or job-factor variable, were excluded ($n = 4$ dropped). The **baseline analytical sample contains 48 respondents**. Summary statistics for key variables are shown in Table 1.

Table 1: Summary Statistics ($n = 48$)

Variable	Mean	SD	p_5	p_{95}	Min	Max
Demographics						
Age	27.5	3.6	24	34	24	43
Female	0.38	0.49	0.00	1.00	0	1
Married	0.10	0.31	0.00	1.00	0	1
Has children	0.08	0.28	0.00	1.00	0	1
Wages (monthly GHC)						
Minimum WTA	2248	1624	100	4000	18	10000
Maximum WTA	4260	2647	250	10000	30	10000

Notes: Female, Married, and Has children are binary (0/1) indicators; their means equal the share of the sample with that characteristic. p_5 and p_{95} for wage variables are the winsorisation thresholds used in Table 4. Wages standardised to monthly GHC equivalents using a 40-hour, 5-day working week.

2 Prevalence of Job-Choice Factors

Respondents were asked which factors influence their job-choice decisions. Table 2 shows the reported prevalence of each factor.

Table 2: Respondents Citing Each Factor as Influencing Job Choice ($n = 48$)

Factor	Count	Share
Professional development	37	77.1%
Location	36	75.0%
Hours flexibility	36	75.0%
Training	30	62.5%
Qualifications match	19	39.6%
Promotion prospects	14	29.2%
Family opinion	6	12.5%
Peer opinion	1	2.1%

Note: The one respondent citing peer opinion is included among the six citing family opinion.

The striking rarity of stated social influence, particularly peer opinion (cited by only one respondent), sets up an important contrast with the regression results discussed in Section 3, where both social factors emerge as statistically significant predictors of the *maximum* acceptable wage.

3 Regression Results

We estimate four OLS regressions, each using heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. The outcome is either the minimum or the maximum monthly wage WTA (in GHC). Predictors are eight binary job-factor indicators (location, family opinion, peer opinion, hours flexibility, qualifications match, promotion prospects, professional development, and training). Two specifications add age and gender (female) as demographic controls.

Table 3 summarises the direction and significance of notable coefficients. Full regression output is available in the Stata log. Four respondents provided a minimum but not a maximum wage, so models (3) and (4) use 44 observations.

Table 3: Summary of OLS Regression Results

	Min WTA		**Max WTA**	
Job factor	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Significant predictors				
Professional development	$+^{**}$	$+^{**}$	$+^{***}$	$+^{***}$
Family opinion	ns	ns	$-^{***}$	$-^{***}$
Peer opinion	ns	ns	$+^{***}$	$+^{**}$
Non-significant predictors				
Location	ns	ns	ns	ns
Hours flexibility	ns	ns	ns	ns
Qualifications match	ns	ns	ns	ns
Promotion prospects	ns	ns	ns	ns
Training	ns	ns	ns	ns
Controls (age, female)		✓		✓
N	48	48	44	44

Note: + / − indicates coefficient direction; ns = not significant. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05 (robust standard errors). Salary excluded from all models (see Section 4).

3.1 Minimum Wage WTA

Of all job-factor indicators, **professional development** is the only significant predictor of a respondent's minimum acceptable wage (significant at the 5% level, $p < 0.05$, in both specifications). The positive coefficient indicates that respondents who cite professional development as important in their job choice name a *higher* wage floor. This is consistent with a self-selection story: individuals oriented toward career growth may have higher reservation wages, either because they feel their human capital warrants more or because they are willing to wait for a better match. The result is robust to the inclusion of age and gender as controls.

No other job-factor indicator (location, hours flexibility, qualifications match, promotion, or training) is significantly associated with the minimum WTA.

3.2 Maximum Wage WTA

Three job-factor indicators are significantly associated with the maximum acceptable wage ($n = 44$):

- **Professional development** is associated with a significantly *higher* maximum WTA in both specifications ($p = 0.009$ without controls; $p = 0.006$ with controls). The coefficient is substantially larger for the ceiling than for the floor, suggesting career-oriented graduates set higher aspirations across the board.
- **Family opinion** is associated with a significantly *lower* maximum WTA ($p = 0.001$ in both specifications). Respondents who report that family opinion matters in their job choice name a lower ceiling wage. One interpretation is that family networks may channel graduates toward sectors where salaries are typically modest, or may reflect conservative reference points for expected pay in the local graduate labour market.
- **Peer opinion** is associated with a significantly *higher* maximum WTA ($p = 0.005$ without controls; $p = 0.026$ with controls). This could reflect peer networks that set high wage norms, or social comparison dynamics that raise wage aspirations.

The controlled specification (model 4) also reveals a significant negative association between age and maximum WTA ($p = 0.044$), suggesting older respondents in the sample set lower wage ceilings.

4 Noteworthy Observations

The stated–revealed disconnect. The most striking pattern in the data is the mismatch between how *few* respondents explicitly report social factors as important in their job decisions (1 of 48 for peer opinion; 6 of 48 for family opinion) and the statistical prominence of those same factors in the maximum WTA regressions, where both are significant at the 1% level. This disconnect may indicate that social influences operate at a level respondents do not consciously attribute to their decision-making, an interesting hypothesis to explore in subsequent work.

Asymmetry between social factors and professional development. Social factors (family and peer opinion) are significant only for the maximum (ceiling) WTA, not the minimum (floor). Professional development, by contrast, is significant for both: it raises the floor (by roughly GHC 860–870/month) and raises the ceiling by a larger margin (roughly GHC 2,200–2,450/month). This pattern suggests that career-oriented graduates set higher wages across the board, while social reference points shape aspiration levels but not reservation prices.

Salary excluded from regressions. The salary job-factor indicator was not included as a predictor in any regression. This is appropriate: using "does salary matter to you?" as a predictor of the actual salary you demand would introduce a form of circularity (it measures the same underlying construct as the outcome), potentially inflating coefficients and distorting inference on other factors.

Wage data heterogeneity. The free-text wage format produced responses in at least four different time units (hourly, daily, monthly, ranges) and in multiple currencies and spellings. The algorithmic standardisation procedure handles these cases, but some uncertainty remains; for example, a respondent who wrote "GHC 3,000 and above" is treated as having stated exactly GHC 3,000. Measurement error in the outcome variable reduces statistical power and may affect regression estimates.

5 Robustness: Winsorised Wages

The raw wage data include extreme values at both ends (e.g. a minimum WTA of GHC 18 and a maximum of GHC 10,000 per month) that may reflect measurement or reporting noise rather than genuine preferences. To assess whether these extreme values drive the main results, we re-estimate all four regressions after winsorising both wage outcomes at the 5th and 95th percentiles: values below the 5th percentile are set to the 5th percentile value, and values above the 95th are set to the 95th. This limits the influence of outliers without discarding any observations.

Table 4 reports the results. The winsorisation affected 4 minimum-wage observations (2 below GHC 100 and 2 above GHC 4,000) and 2 maximum-wage observations (below GHC 250; none exceeded the 95th percentile of GHC 10,000). All significant findings are robust: professional development retains its sign, direction, and significance for both the minimum ($p = 0.026$; $p = 0.035$ with controls) and maximum WTA ($p = 0.009$; $p = 0.006$), family opinion remains negatively associated with the maximum WTA at the 1% level, and peer opinion remains positive and significant ($p = 0.005$ without controls; $p = 0.027$ with controls). Point estimates for non-significant minimum-WTA predictors shift more (notably training, which roughly halves, and hours flexibility, which moves near zero), though none cross a significance threshold, suggesting those estimates are sensitive to a small number of extreme values.

Table 4: OLS Regression Results: Winsorised WTA (5th/95th Percentile)

	Min WTA		**Max WTA**	
Job factor	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Significant predictors				
Professional development	$+^{**}$	$+^{**}$	$+^{***}$	$+^{***}$
Family opinion	ns	ns	$-^{***}$	$-^{***}$
Peer opinion	ns	ns	$+^{***}$	$+^{**}$
Non-significant predictors				
Location	ns	ns	ns	ns
Hours flexibility	ns	ns	ns	ns
Qualifications match	ns	ns	ns	ns
Promotion prospects	ns	ns	ns	ns
Training	ns	ns	ns	ns
Controls (age, female)		✓		✓
N	48	48	44	44

Note: + / − indicates coefficient direction; ns = not significant. *** $p<0.01$, ** $p<0.05$ (robust standard errors). Salary excluded from all models (see Section 4).

6 Next Steps

The associations documented here, particularly the divergent roles of social factors and professional development across the wage floor and ceiling, provide a useful starting point for designing a pilot RCT that could isolate the mechanisms at play. Expanding the sample and cross-tabulating wage WTA by field of study and graduation year are natural immediate next steps before pilot design.